

Fig 11.1: Food Sources of Vitamin A

- It helps in maintaining healthy skin and epithelial tissues.
- It is important for proper growth of bones.
- It helps in normal development of foetus
- It protects the mucous membrane of the digestive, respiratory and urinary tracts against infection.

Food Sources of Vitamin A

Vitamin A is present as retinol in animal sources such as egg yolk, fish (halibut, shark, cod), liver and cod liver oil. In plants, it is found in the form of carotene which gets converted to vitamin A in the body. Carrot, beetroot, turnip, papaya, mango, pumpkin, tomatoes, green leafy vegetables, drumstick, whole milk, butter, ghee etc., are very good sources of carotene.

Symptoms of Vitamin A deficiency

1. **Night blindness:** This is also called as Nyctalopia. Initially there is itching, burning and inflammation of eyelids and the person gradually loses vision in dim light.
2. **Keratomalacia:** This occurs due to poor intake or poor absorption of vitamin A. When conjunctival xerosis (conjunctival dryness) is not treated it may develop into a condition known as keratomalacia where the Cornea becomes dull and cloudy.
3. **Xerophthalmia:** The conjunctiva and corneaof the eyes become extremely dry, thickened and wrinkled followed by progressive cloudiness. This is due to keratinisation of the epithelial cells over the cornea. This condition

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